

The Most Dangerous Game

Richard Connell · 1924

First published: Collier's, 19 Jan 1924

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay
Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/O._Henry_Memorial_Award_Prize_Stories_of_1924/The_Most_Dangerous_Game (revision 12072546), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 8–10 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Most Dangerous Game suggest about hunter and hunted?
- What does The Most Dangerous Game suggest about civilization and savagery?
- What does The Most Dangerous Game suggest about survival?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	The Most Dangerous Game	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*hunter and hunted* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: The Most Dangerous Game

Focus: the hunter becoming the hunted

Content note (killing of humans for sport, violence): Sensitive content: Killing of humans for sport; violence. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes killing of humans for sport; violence.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Big-game hunter Sanger Rainsford falls overboard near Ship-Trap Island and finds the chateau of General Zaroff, a Russian aristocrat bored with hunting animals who now hunts shipwrecked sailors. Rainsford refuses to join and becomes the prey for three days. He builds traps that kill a servant and a hound, then leaps into the sea. That night he waits in Zaroff's bedroom; they fight, and Rainsford sleeps in Zaroff's bed.

Background: Published in Collier's on 19 January 1924, after the First World War, in which Connell served. Big-game safaris were a fashionable sport.

Significance: Among the most anthologized American stories; it appears in Glencoe's grade 9 lesson plans and Gale's Short Stories for Students, vol. 1.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: Is it ever acceptable to hunt for sport? Where would you draw the line? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes killing of humans for sport; violence.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are canopied, focused, loudness, bizarre, wrestled. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "It was to a huge, beam-ceilinged bedroom with a canopied bed big enough for six men that Rainsford followed the silent giant." In this sentence it means: covered overhead like a canopy. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of The Most Dangerous Game would have known. Published in Collier's on 19 January 1924, after the First World War, in which Connell served. Big-game safaris were a fashionable sport. Why does this story matter? Among the most anthologized American stories; it appears in Glencoe's grade 9 lesson plans and Gale's Short Stories for Students, vol. 1. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for conflict.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "He struggled up to the surface and tried to cry out, but the wash from the speeding yacht slapped him in the face and the salt water in his open mouth made him gag and strangle." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to the hunter becoming the hunted? I circle "wrestled", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find conflict, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for conflict.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of conflict. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *He struggled up to the surface and tried to cry out, but the wash from the speeding yacht slapped him in the face and the salt water in his open mouth made him gag and strangle. Desperately he struck out with strong strokes after the receding lights of the yacht, but he stopped before he had swum fifty feet. A certain cool-headedness had come to him; it was not the first time he had been in a tight place. There was a chance that his cries could be heard by someone aboard the yacht, but that chance was slender, and grew more slender as the yacht raced on. He wrestled himself out of his clothes, and shouted with all his power. The lights of the yacht became faint and ever-vanishing fireflies; then they were blotted out entirely by the night.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Conflict, Foreshadowing, Irony: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Most Dangerous Game develops the idea of the hunter becoming the hunted. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of conflict and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to hunter and hunted? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about the hunter becoming the hunted, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how conflict shapes the hunter becoming the hunted. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
canopied (verb)	covered overhead like a canopy	*It was to a huge, beam-ceilinged bedroom with a canopied bed big enough for six men that Rainsford followed the silent giant.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
focused (verb)	fixed; concentrated (on a target)	*Toward morning when a dingy gray was varnishing the sky, the cry of some startled bird focused Rainsford's attention in that direction.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
loudness (noun)	the quality of being loud	*He let it fall, and it startled him with its booming loudness.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
bizarre (adjective)	conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual	*Rainsford's first impression was that the man was singularly handsome; his second was that there was an original, almost bizarre quality about the general's face.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
wrestled (verb)	combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force	*He wrestled himself out of his clothes, and shouted with all his power.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
complimented (verb)	praised	*When I shot some of his prize turkeys with it, he did not punish me; he complimented me on my marksmanship.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
protruding (verb)	extend out or project in space	*His foot touched the protruding bough that was the trigger.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
affable (adjective)	diffusing warmth and friendliness	*He was finding the general a most thoughtful and affable host, a true cosmopolite.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
crouched (verb)			

	bend one's back forward from the waist on down	*Then, wet with sweat and aching with tiredness, he crouched behind the stump of a lightning-charred tree.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
luckily (adverb)	by good fortune	*I, luckily, had invested heavily in American securities, so I shall never have to open a tea room in Monte Carlo or drive a taxi in Paris.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Is it ever acceptable to hunt for sport? Where would you draw the line?
2. Where does conflict appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with hunter and hunted?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How does Rainsford reach the island? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: He falls off a yacht and swims ashore
2. What does Zaroff hunt? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Human beings
3. What is Ship-Trap Island known for? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Sailors' dread of it
4. How long must Rainsford survive to win? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Three days
5. Where does the story end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: In Zaroff's bedroom, with Rainsford in the bed
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Most Dangerous Game" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Big-game hunter Sanger Rainsford falls overboard near Ship-Trap Island and finds the chateau of General Zaroff, a Russian aristocrat bored with hunting animals who now hunts shipwrecked sailors. Rainsford refuses to join and becomes the prey for three days. He builds traps that kill a servant and a hound, then leaps into the sea. That night he waits in Zaroff's bedroom; they fight, and Rainsford…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Most Dangerous Game"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Most Dangerous Game" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "It was to a huge, beam-ceilinged bedroom with a canopied bed big enough for six men that Rainsford followed the silent giant." What does "canopied" mean here, and what is literally happening in

this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: canopied: covered overhead like a canopy.

10. Reread: “Toward morning when a dingy gray was varnishing the sky, the cry of some startled bird focused Rainsford’s attention in that direction.” What does “focused” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: focused: fixed; concentrated (on a target).

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Most Dangerous Game” suggest about the hunter becoming the hunted? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: Among the most anthologized American stories; it appears in Glencoe's grade 9 lesson plans and Gale's Short Stories for Students, vol. 1.
2. Find one example of conflict in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for the forces, people or desires pulling against each other.
3. How does the foreshadowing in this story shape what we understand about the hunter becoming the hunted? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.
4. In the passage that begins “He struggled up to the surface and tried to cry out, but the wash from the speeding yacht slapped him in the face and the salt water in his open mouth made him gag and strangle.”, why might Connell have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Most Dangerous Game”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Big-game hunter Sanger Rainsford falls overboard near Ship-Trap Island and finds the chateau of General Zaroff, a Russian aristocrat bored with hunting animals who now hunts shipwrecked sailors. Rainsford refuses to join and becomes the prey for three days. He builds traps that kill a servant and a…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Most Dangerous Game” set up that the rest of The Most Dangerous Game will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Is it ever acceptable to hunt for sport? Where would you draw the line?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does irony appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with hunter and hunted? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
10. Background: Published in Collier's on 19 January 1924, after the First World War, in which Connell served. Big-game safaris were a fashionable sport. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment

in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "Among the most anthologized American stories; it appears in Glencoe's grade 9 lesson plans and Gale's Short Stories for Students, vol. 1." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "The Most Dangerous Game" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about the hunter becoming the hunted? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Most Dangerous Game": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to civilization and savagery: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Connell need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the conflict in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "The Most Dangerous Game" treats the hunter becoming the hunted with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Most Dangerous Game see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve hunter and hunted? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the hunter becoming the hunted? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Richard Connell about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Conflict:** look for the forces, people or desires pulling against each other (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Foreshadowing**: hints, warnings or images that point to later events
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true

Chapter quiz

1. How does Rainsford reach the island?
   A. He falls off a yacht and swims ashore
   B. His plane crashes
   C. He is invited
   D. He is shipwrecked in a storm with friends
2. What does Zaroff hunt?
   A. Deer
   B. Wild boars
   C. Human beings
   D. Tigers
3. What is Ship-Trap Island known for?
   A. Sailors' dread of it
   B. Rare birds
   C. Gold mines
   D. A lighthouse
4. How long must Rainsford survive to win?
   A. One night
   B. A week
   C. Three days
   D. A month
5. Where does the story end?
   A. On the yacht
   B. In Zaroff's bedroom, with Rainsford in the bed
   C. At sea
   D. In the jungle
6. In the line “It was to a huge, beam-ceilinged bedroom with a canopied bed big enough for six men that Rainsford followed the silent giant.”, what does “canopied” most nearly mean?
   A. fixed; concentrated (on a target)
   B. covered overhead like a canopy
   C. the quality of being loud
   D. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual
7. In the line “Toward morning when a dingy gray was varnishing the sky, the cry of some startled bird focused Rainsford’s attention in that direction.”, what does “focused” most nearly mean?
   A. fixed; concentrated (on a target)
   B. covered overhead like a canopy
   C. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual
   D. the quality of being loud

Answer key: 1. A (He falls off a yacht and swims ashore); 2. C (Human beings); 3. A (Sailors' dread of it); 4. C (Three days); 5. B (In Zaroff's bedroom, with Rainsford in the bed); 6. B (covered overhead like a canopy); 7. A (fixed; concentrated (on a target))

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.3, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "The Most Dangerous Game," how does Connell show the hunter becoming the hunted? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the conflict you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The Most Dangerous Game, how does Connell develop the idea of the hunter becoming the hunted? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the conflict in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Most Dangerous Game develops the idea of the hunter becoming the hunted. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of conflict and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Most Dangerous Game (where it begins, turns and ends) and its conflict shape the reader's understanding of the hunter becoming the hunted. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Most Dangerous Game suggests about the hunter becoming the hunted. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's conflict and foreshadowing), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Richard Connell uses conflict in The Most Dangerous Game to complicate the reader's understanding of the hunter becoming the hunted. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Most Dangerous Game within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of the hunter becoming the hunted responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Most Dangerous Game alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of the hunter becoming the hunted follows or bends those conventions, using the conflict as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Most Dangerous Game and its treatment of the hunter becoming the hunted. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's conflict and foreshadowing, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Most Dangerous Game as evidence for a larger claim about the hunter becoming the hunted in The Most Dangerous Game. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Most Dangerous Game as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of the hunter becoming the hunted. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Most Dangerous Game.

SAT-style questions

1. *He let it fall, and it startled him with its booming loudness.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “loudness” most nearly mean?

   A. bend one's back forward from the waist on down

   B. diffusing warmth and friendliness

   C. the quality of being loud

   D. by good fortune

2. *He struggled up to the surface and tried to cry out, but the wash from the speeding yacht slapped him in the face and the salt water in his open mouth made him gag and strangle. Desperately he struck out with strong strokes after the receding lights of the yacht, but he stopped before he had swum fifty feet. A certain cool-headedness had come to him; it was not the first time he had been in a tight place. There was a chance that his cries could be heard by someone aboard the yacht, but that chance was slender, and grew more slender as the yacht raced on. He wrestled himself out of his clothes, and shouted with all his power. The lights of the yacht became faint and ever-vanishing fireflies; then they were blotted out entirely by the night.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Most Dangerous Game”?

   A. The hunter becoming the hunted

   B. Love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence

   C. Reason struggling against terror

   D. The cost of wanting to seem richer than you are

SAT key: 1. C (the quality of being loud); 2. A (The hunter becoming the hunted)

Whole-book test

The Most Dangerous Game: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. How does Rainsford reach the island?
   A. He falls off a yacht and swims ashore
   B. His plane crashes
   C. He is invited
   D. He is shipwrecked in a storm with friends
2. What does Zaroff hunt?
   A. Deer
   B. Wild boars
   C. Human beings
   D. Tigers
3. What is Ship-Trap Island known for?
   A. Sailors' dread of it
   B. Rare birds
   C. Gold mines
   D. A lighthouse
4. How long must Rainsford survive to win?
   A. One night
   B. A week
   C. Three days
   D. A month
5. Where does the story end?
   A. On the yacht
   B. In Zaroff's bedroom, with Rainsford in the bed
   C. At sea
   D. In the jungle
6. In the line “It was to a huge, beam-ceilinged bedroom with a canopied bed big enough for six men that Rainsford followed the silent giant.”, what does “canopied” most nearly mean?
   A. fixed; concentrated (on a target)
   B. covered overhead like a canopy
   C. the quality of being loud
   D. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

7. In the line “Toward morning when a dingy gray was varnishing the sky, the cry of some startled bird focused Rainsford’s attention in that direction.”, what does “focused” most nearly mean?
   A. fixed; concentrated (on a target)
   B. covered overhead like a canopy
   C. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual
   D. the quality of being loud
8. As used in the story (“It was to a huge, beam-ceilinged bedroom with a canopied bed big enough for six men that Rainsford followed the silent giant.”), what does “canopied” mean?
   A. covered overhead like a canopy
   B. combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force
   C. diffusing warmth and friendliness
   D. fixed; concentrated (on a target)
9. As used in the story (“Toward morning when a dingy gray was varnishing the sky, the cry of some startled bird focused Rainsford’s attention in that direction.”), what does “focused” mean?
   A. praised
   B. fixed; concentrated (on a target)
   C. bend one's back forward from the waist on down
   D. the quality of being loud
10. As used in the story (“He let it fall, and it startled him with its booming loudness.”), what does “loudness” mean?
    A. extend out or project in space
    B. by good fortune
    C. the quality of being loud
    D. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual
11. As used in the story (“Rainsford’s first impression was that the man was singularly handsome; his second was that there was an original, almost bizarre quality abo”), what does “bizarre” mean?
    A. diffusing warmth and friendliness
    B. covered overhead like a canopy
    C. combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force
    D. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual
12. As used in the story (“He wrestled himself out of his clothes, and shouted with all his power.”), what does “wrestled” mean?
    A. combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force
    B. bend one's back forward from the waist on down
    C. fixed; concentrated (on a target)
    D. praised

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how hunter and hunted develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how civilization and savagery develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how survival develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (hunter and hunted, civilization and savagery, survival) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. A (He falls off a yacht and swims ashore); 2. C (Human beings); 3. A (Sailors' dread of it); 4. C (Three days); 5. B (In Zaroff's bedroom, with Rainsford in the bed); 6. B (covered overhead like a canopy); 7. A (fixed; concentrated (on a target)); 8. A (covered overhead like a canopy); 9. B (fixed; concentrated (on a target)); 10. C (the quality of being loud); 11. D (conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual); 12. A (combat to overcome an opposing tendency or force)

Essay assignments

Essay: Hunter and hunted

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Most Dangerous Game teaches about hunter and hunted. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Richard Connell develops hunter and hunted in The Most Dangerous Game. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Richard Connell develops hunter and hunted across The Most Dangerous Game. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Most Dangerous Game (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of hunter and hunted. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of hunter and hunted in The Most Dangerous Game. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Richard Connell's choices in The Most Dangerous Game (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of hunter and hunted, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Most Dangerous Game's treatment of hunter and hunted in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on hunter and hunted in The Most Dangerous Game that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on hunter and hunted in The Most Dangerous Game. Name your

critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about hunter and hunted in The Most Dangerous Game, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on hunter and hunted in The Most Dangerous Game, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Civilization and savagery

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Most Dangerous Game teaches about civilization and savagery. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Richard Connell develops civilization and savagery in The Most Dangerous Game. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Richard Connell develops civilization and savagery across The Most Dangerous Game. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Most Dangerous Game (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of civilization and savagery. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of civilization and savagery in The Most Dangerous Game. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Richard Connell's choices in The Most Dangerous Game (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of civilization and savagery, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Most Dangerous Game's treatment of civilization and savagery in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on civilization and savagery in The Most Dangerous Game that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on civilization and savagery in The Most Dangerous Game. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about civilization and savagery in The Most Dangerous Game, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on civilization and savagery in The Most Dangerous Game, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Survival

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Most Dangerous Game teaches about survival. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Richard Connell develops survival in The Most Dangerous Game. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Richard Connell develops survival across The Most Dangerous Game. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Most Dangerous Game (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of survival. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of survival in The Most Dangerous Game. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Richard Connell's choices in The Most Dangerous Game (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of survival, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Most Dangerous Game's treatment of survival in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on survival in The Most Dangerous Game that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on survival in The Most Dangerous Game. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about survival in The Most Dangerous Game, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on survival in The Most Dangerous Game, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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